

*The*

# BURROW NOTEBOOK

*companion to your own notebook*



THIS BOOK BELONGS TO

.....

MY BOOKWORM'S NAME

.....

STARTED ON

.....



Bookwormburrows is a game played around a book. The book might be one your class is reading together, one your teacher picked just for the game, or one your group agreed on.

You play a character called a **bookworm**. A kid like you who can step into the world of a book and become part of the story for a while. The person leading the session is the **DM**, and they play with you. The DM helps the story along, tells you what your bookworm sees and hears, and reads the paragraphs you write. Everyone playing together is the **party**.

A **session** is one time you meet to play. It might be a class period, a club hour, a tutoring sitting, or a quiet afternoon at home. A **campaign** is the whole story you play through together, session after session, until the book is finished.



When you play this game, you write things down. Most of what you write goes in any notebook you already love. A school notebook, a journal you keep, a small notebook for your pocket. Whatever feels right in your hand. This little book is the helper that goes with it.

### WHAT LIVES IN HERE

- The X-card you can raise when the story feels like too much
- Your Lines and Veils, the list of things to keep out of the game
- The book your party is stepping into right now
- How outcomes work in this game
- The shapes to use in your own notebook for keeping track of people, places, and everything else
- A running list of every book you ever step into with your bookworm

### WHAT GOES IN YOUR OWN NOTEBOOK

- Everything that happens during a session
- Every Roll Page (more about those later in this book)
- The people your bookworm meets
- The places your bookworm visits
- Open questions, things you are carrying, letters home, maps, anything else

*Whatever feels good to draw, sketch, write, or scribble belongs in your own notebook. This little book stays small on purpose.*



*Every campaign starts inside a book. Write down what you know about it before your bookworm walks in.*

**TITLE OF THE BOOK**

.....

**WHO WROTE IT**

.....

**WHEN AND WHERE THE STORY TAKES PLACE**

.....

.....

**THREE WORDS FOR THIS WORLD**

.....

.....



*Draw something or someone from the cover of the book*

**WHAT I HOPE WILL HAPPEN**

.....

.....

.....

**WHAT I AM A LITTLE WORRIED ABOUT**

.....

.....

.....



## WHEN THE STORY STARTS TO FEEL LIKE TOO MUCH

*Open this book to this page and hold it up so everyone can see it. You can also just say 'X' out loud. The moment you do, your DM stops the scene. Everyone at the table moves to something easier.*



*The X-card belongs to every bookworm at the table. Anyone can raise it any time, for any reason. You can keep playing your character. That part of the story just gets skipped over.*



Before you start playing, write down two kinds of things. **Lines** are things to keep out of the game completely. **Veils** are things that can happen in the story but stay off-screen. Your DM will skip over those parts. Fill in the boxes below before play starts. Your DM keeps them off the table.

### MY LINES · things to keep out of the game

|       |
|-------|
| ..... |
| ..... |
| ..... |
| ..... |
| ..... |

### MY VEILS · things that happen off-screen

|       |
|-------|
| ..... |
| ..... |
| ..... |
| ..... |
| ..... |

*The open door.* You can step out of any session whenever you want, for any reason. Everyone at the table knows you can always leave and come back.



A session is one time you all sit down to play. Your bookworm burrows into a book, meets some people, walks through some places, and decides what to do. You write all of it down. Here is the shape of a session.

### BEFORE

Open your own notebook to a fresh page. Write today's date at the top, and which book your party is reading.

### DURING

Write what is happening as it happens. Use one page for words and the other for sketches if you like. When your bookworm wants to do something hard or tricky, you write a Roll Page (see page 11).

### AFTER

Before you close your notebook, look back at what you wrote. Find the questions still hanging in the air. Pick one you want to come back to next time and circle it. Add any new people or places to your running lists.





In this game, your writing is what decides what happens. Other games use dice. This one uses what you write. When your bookworm tries something, you write a paragraph about how they do it. Your DM reads what you wrote and tells you the outcome. The better the paragraph, the better the action turns out.



### STRONG

Your paragraph is clear and full of details. Your bookworm's action works the way you wanted. Your DM tells you the success.



### MIXED

Your paragraph is part of the way there. Some of what you tried works. The rest comes out different than you hoped. Your DM tells you both halves.



### WEAK

Your paragraph is short, rushed, or hard to follow. The world pushes back. Your DM tells you an outcome that surprises you.

*If the outcome was weak, try again next time with a different idea. Every bookworm writes weak paragraphs sometimes. Just keep writing. Every paragraph you write makes you better at it.*



*Here is the shape to use for each session in your own notebook. Adjust it to fit how you like to write.*

### THE SHAPE

At the top of a fresh page, write today's **DATE**. Underneath, write **WHERE WE ARE** and put down the book and the place. Then write **WHAT HAPPENED** across the page. Underneath that, fill in what is happening. You can write as your bookworm ('I climbed the wall and saw the river') or as yourself ('Brock told us about his glasses'). Either one is fine.

At the bottom of the page, leave three lines for **OPEN THREADS**. These are the questions still hanging in the air after the session. Things you wonder about. Promises your bookworm made. Mysteries the party can come back to later.

### A SMALL EXAMPLE

*Say your bookworm has just burrowed into a forest book and the party met an old badger at a crossroads. Your log might begin:*

**DATE:** Saturday, March 4

**WHERE WE ARE:** the forest book, at the crossroads near the tall stones

**WHAT HAPPENED:**

*We came out of the burrow at sunset. There was an old badger sitting on a tree stump. He said his glasses were lost and he could no longer read the maps. The party agreed to help him find them...*

**OPEN THREADS:**

*Who took the glasses? Why is the badger reading maps? What is at the tall stones?*



A Roll Page is what you write when your bookworm wants to do something hard or tricky. The paragraph you write is what your DM reads to decide what happens.

### THE SHAPE

In your own notebook, when it is your bookworm's turn to try something, start a fresh section. Write **WHAT I AM TRYING TO DO** on one short line. Then write **HOW I AM TRYING TO DO IT** as a small paragraph. Six to eight lines is a good size.

Leave a small space at the bottom marked **OUTCOME**, with three boxes: **STRONG**, **MIXED**, **WEAK**. Your DM marks one after reading. If you would rather, the DM can just tell you out loud.

### A SMALL EXAMPLE

#### WHAT I AM TRYING TO DO:

*Climb the tall stones to see over the forest.*

#### HOW I AM TRYING TO DO IT:

*I find the lowest stone first and test the moss with my boot. It holds. I put my fingers into a crack the rain has opened and pull myself up slowly, one hand at a time, listening for crows. At the top I crouch low and look toward the river...*

**OUTCOME:**    ☐ **STRONG**    ☐ **MIXED**    ☐ **WEAK**



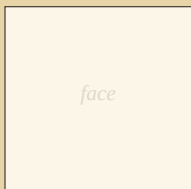
*Every bookworm meets people inside the book. Some help. Some get in the way. Some change everything. Keep a list in your own notebook so you can find them again.*

### THE SHAPE

For each new person, write a small card with **NAME**, **FROM** (which book or which part of the world), **WANTS** (one short line), and **MOOD** (friend, unsure, or enemy, pick one).

Leave a small box at the top for a face drawing if you want one. Two or three sentences underneath for anything else worth remembering.

### A SMALL EXAMPLE



**NAME:** Brock  
**FROM:** the forest book  
**WANTS:** his lost glasses  
**MOOD:** friend

*He has been a forester since before the party's parents were born. His left ear is torn. He smelled like wet bark and pipe smoke.*

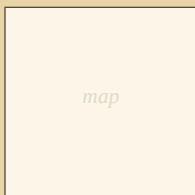


*Places change as your bookworm walks through them. A small entry for each one helps you find your way back later.*

### THE SHAPE

For each new place, write **NAME**, **IN WHICH BOOK**, **THREE THINGS I NOTICED** (two short lines), and **WHY WE MIGHT COME BACK** (one line). A small map drawing next to it helps you remember the shape of the place. If you find a picture or two that look like this place, paste them in.

### A SMALL EXAMPLE



**NAME:**

*The tall stones at the crossroads*

**IN WHICH BOOK:**

*the forest book*

**THREE THINGS I NOTICED:**

*crows on every stone, moss only on the north sides, a carved word my bookworm could not read*

**WHY WE MIGHT COME BACK:***the carved word*



*Open threads are the questions still hanging in the air after a session. A question your bookworm has. A promise the party made. A mystery still waiting for an answer. The party can pull on any thread later.*

### THE SHAPE

In your own notebook, keep a numbered list. Each entry gets a short description of the thread, the session number when it started, and a blank space for the session number when it closes.

When a thread closes, check it off and write the closing session number. Threads stay open as long as they need to. Some last the whole campaign.

### A SMALL EXAMPLE

1. *Find the badger's lost glasses.* (Started: session 2.)
2. *Find out what the carved word at the tall stones means.* (Started: session 2.)
3. *Figure out why the crows sit in groups of three.* (Started: session 3.)



*Some things are on your bookworm. Some things are shared by the party. Both lists matter, especially when the party splits up.*

### THE SHAPE

Two short lists in your own notebook. **On me** for what your bookworm is carrying. **With the party** for what you are all carrying together. For each item, write the session number when you picked it up. That way you can remember where it came from later.

### A SMALL EXAMPLE

#### ON ME:

*a small knife (session 1), a coil of rope (session 3), the badger's paper map (session 4)*

#### WITH THE PARTY:

*a brass lantern (session 1), enough bread for two more days (session 4)*

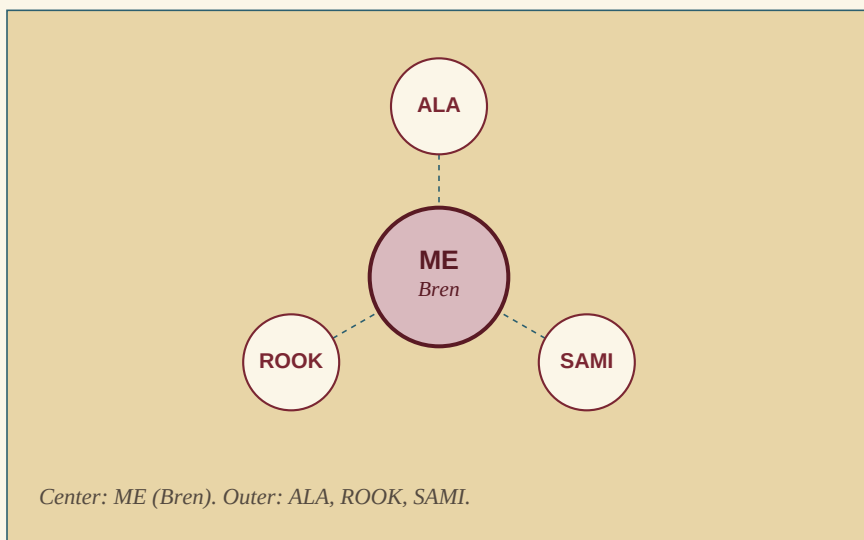


*The other bookworms at the table are the most important part of the story. Keep track of what they mean to your bookworm and how that changes.*

### THE SHAPE

In your own notebook, draw a small circle in the middle of a page. Put your bookworm's name in it. Around that center, draw a smaller circle for each other bookworm in your party. Draw a line from the center to each one. Next to each line, write a few words about what that other bookworm means to your bookworm right now.

Draw this page over again every few sessions. The bonds will change.







*A letter home is a page you write as your bookworm to someone they care about. A page from your bookworm's diary works too. Letters work in a different way from Roll Pages. Your DM may read it and let it shape what happens in a later session.*

### THE SHAPE

In your own notebook, on a fresh page, write **TO** with the name of the person you are writing to. Or the name of your diary. Then the letter itself, in your bookworm's voice. Then **FROM** with your bookworm's name.

Write between sessions, while you are at home. A letter is your bookworm's quiet time. Pick a day that mattered to your bookworm and write about that one.

|                   |
|-------------------|
| <b>TO</b> .....   |
| .....             |
| .....             |
| .....             |
| .....             |
| .....             |
| .....             |
| .....             |
| <b>FROM</b> ..... |



*A map is your bookworm's memory of a place. It can be rough. It can be a sketch with a few labels. It can be detailed if you love drawing.*

### THE SHAPE

Keep maps in your own notebook on a fresh page. If you have graph paper, that works well. At the top, write the name of the place and the session you drew it. Add a small arrow pointing north so you know which way is up.

Draw only the part your bookworm has actually seen. The map grows session by session as the party walks further.

**MAP OF:** *the tall stones at the crossroads*



*A short list to run through between one session and the next. All of it is optional. Pick whatever helps.*

- ☐ Look at your last session log. Read it once.
- ☐ Add any new people to your people list.
- ☐ Add any new places to your places list.
- ☐ Add any new threads. Cross off threads that closed.
- ☐ Update what your bookworm is carrying.
- ☐ Write a letter home if there is something your bookworm wants to say.
- ☐ Read one chapter from the book your party is burrowing into.



*Some questions are always allowed. Pull from this list whenever you feel stuck.*

1. What does this place smell like?
2. What do I notice that the others might miss?
3. Has my bookworm been here before?
4. Does anyone here know my bookworm by name?
5. What time of day is it?
6. What is in arm's reach?
7. What sound is loudest right now?
8. Can I take a moment to think before I act?
9. Can I ask another bookworm for help here?
10. What is the closest way out?



*Every campaign ends inside a book. Keep a running list of where your bookworm has been. One day this list will tell you who they have become.*

| #  | BOOK  | STARTED | FINISHED | ONE MOMENT TO KEEP |
|----|-------|---------|----------|--------------------|
| 01 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 02 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 03 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 04 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 05 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 06 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 07 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 08 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 09 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 10 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 11 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 12 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 13 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 14 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 15 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |



| #  | BOOK  | STARTED | FINISHED | ONE MOMENT TO KEEP |
|----|-------|---------|----------|--------------------|
| 16 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 17 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 18 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
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| 27 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
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| 30 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |



| #  | BOOK  | STARTED | FINISHED | ONE MOMENT TO KEEP |
|----|-------|---------|----------|--------------------|
| 31 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 32 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 33 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 34 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
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| 42 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 43 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 44 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 45 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |

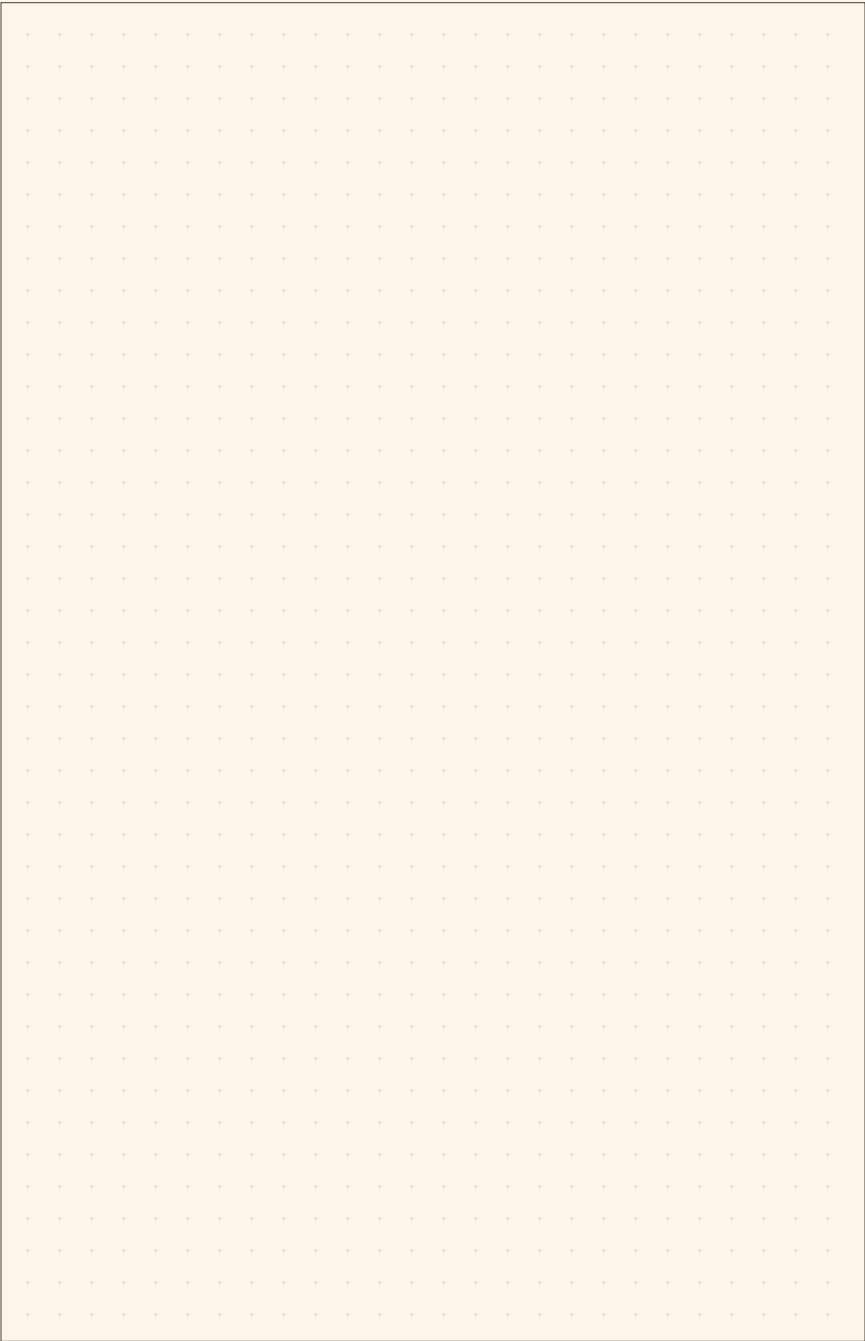


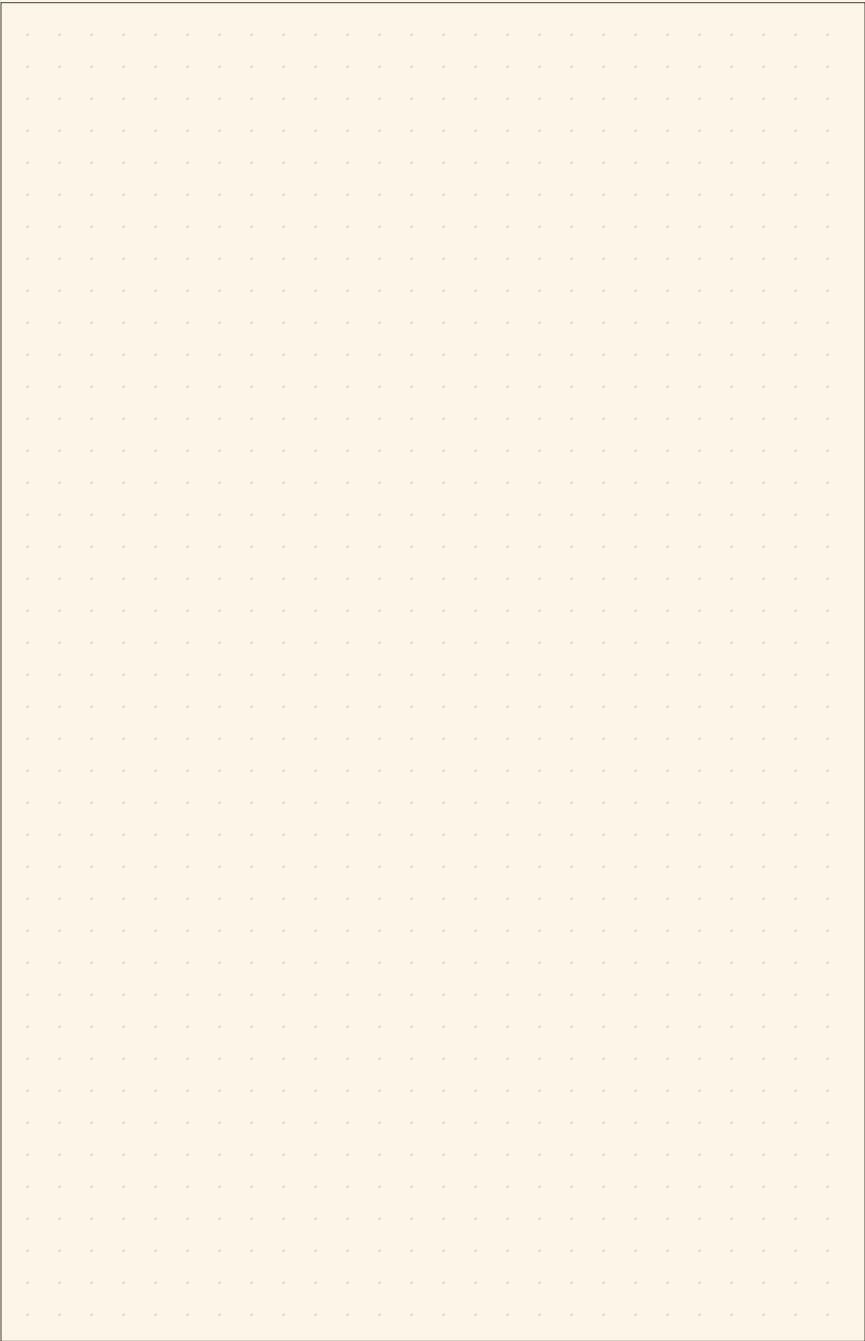
| #  | BOOK  | STARTED | FINISHED | ONE MOMENT TO KEEP |
|----|-------|---------|----------|--------------------|
| 46 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 47 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
| 48 | ..... | .....   | .....    | .....              |
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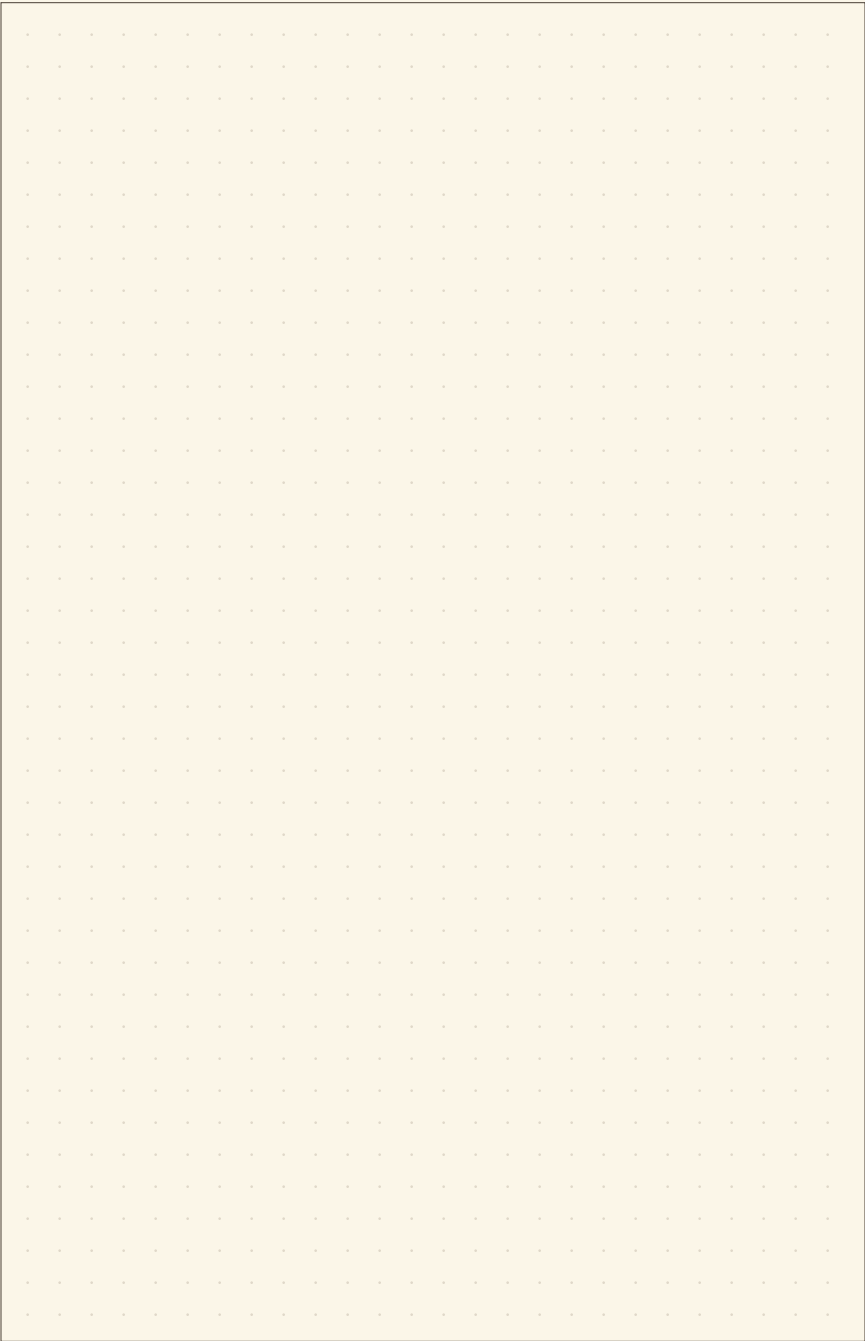














**The Burrow Notebook** is the small companion to whatever notebook you already love. It holds the rules of the game, the safety tools, and the running record of every book you have ever burrowed into. Your own notebook holds everything else.

*Bookwormburrows · Series II · v2.0*

Designed and written by Saul Nassau. The burrow drawing was made just for this book. The book is small on purpose.

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*A small list. Pack it on a tray, in a pencil case, on a shelf, wherever your stuff lives between sessions.*

- ☐ This Burrow Notebook
- ☐ Your own notebook for the session log
- ☐ A pencil you like
- ☐ A second pencil, in case the first one breaks
- ☐ The book your party is burrowing into
- ☐ Your imagination



# THE BURROW NOTEBOOK

*Bookwormburrows · Series II*

[seminarschools.com / notebook](http://seminarschools.com/notebook)

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